“HumAInities: Exploring the Impact of AI on Humanities disciplines”

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Our poster will present the partnership development grant **“HumAInities: Exploring the Impact of AI on Humanities disciplines”**, its goals and expected results. Our project seeks to understand the changes brought about by the impact of artificial intelligence (AI), and in particular generative AI, on the production and dissemination of knowledge within the humanities. The use of artificial intelligence can assist researchers in analyzing substantial amounts of data, extracting meaningful information, and making new discoveries, especially in the field of NLP, which involves analyzing and understanding human language. This approach can be used to extract information from textual documents such as books, articles, and other written works. It can help researchers gain new insights into literature, history, and other fields within the humanities, but it also introduces new challenges, both technical and ethical.

This project brings together 20 researchers from five countries, along with six academic partners, to consider the epistemological implications of generative AI, particularly LLMs, in humanities research. At its heart lies the question of how LLMs, as emergent technological tools, may transform or even expand the scope of humanistic inquiry. Could they, for instance, bridge longstanding divides between qualitative and quantitative approaches? Might they facilitate new forms of engagement with texts, combining statistical data analysis with the nuanced interpretation of cultural artifacts? The answer remains complex. LLMs operate based on patterns derived from vast corpora of data, enabling them to engage in what could be considered preliminary forms of “distant” reading, where they analyze extensive datasets to draw broader patterns and themes. This approach stands in contrast to “close reading,” a traditional humanities method where scholars examine smaller passages of text in detail to extract nuanced meanings, historical context, and socio-political significance. For several years, scholars are working on bridging those two approaches. LLMs could become by far the most convincing way to make “scalable reading” - unifying distant and close reading - the standard method in humanities.

However, in humanities scholarship, objectivity is neither static nor universal; rather, it is shaped by explicit acknowledgment of the researcher’s viewpoint, historical context, and interpretative framework. Humanities scholars are deeply conscious of the subjective nature of their analyses, often embedding their own perspectives within the interpretative process. When using AI for interpretative tasks, one must understand the value systems, assumptions, and biases embedded within the models themselves. In essence, LLMs do not operate from an objective stance but instead reflect the biases and disparities in their training data. This introduces epistemological challenges: Can a machine truly contribute to humanistic understanding if it lacks genuine subjectivity and cultural awareness? What might it mean for an AI system to “interpret” a text or “understand” historical context?

The Impact of LLMs on research is profound, and the originality of our project is to tackle from various disciplinary perspectives three key issues at the heart of the current AI developments as they relate to humanities disciplines:

- Interpretative agency. Traditional humanities research emphasizes the researcher’s role in shaping meaning and understanding. In contrast, LLMs operate on statistical patterns without any subjective comprehension or ethical awareness. This lack of genuine agency raises concerns about the interpretative depth that LLMs can offer. While LLMs might identify correlations or recurring themes, they lack the historical knowledge, empathy, and contextual understanding that human researchers bring to their analyses. Humanities research is not merely about identifying patterns; it is about interpreting these patterns within a larger framework of human experience and social context. Thus, the use of LLMs in the humanities requires that scholars recognize and balance the limitations of these tools and avoid over-relying on them for tasks that demand deeper, more nuanced interpretation.
- Ethics of using LLMs in humanities research. The biases are technical and ethical challenges that can shape the knowledge produced by AI-

driven research. If an LLM reinforces stereotypes or excludes marginalized perspectives, it risks perpetuating systemic inequalities within academia. Sometimes biases are not bugs but features. By acknowledging and addressing the biases within LLMs, humanities scholars can work towards more ethical applications of AI, striving for a model of research that values diversity and inclusion.

- Transparency in AI systems. For LLMs to be trusted tools in humanities research, they must be transparent about their training data, underlying assumptions, and limitations. Scholars need to understand how these models were trained, what data sources were used, and how biases may affect their outputs. This transparency will allow researchers to make informed decisions about when and how to use LLMs. For instance, a researcher using an LLM trained primarily on Western sources might approach its interpretations of non-Western texts with caution, recognizing the model's cultural limitations. In this way, transparency is not just a technical requirement but an ethical imperative that empowers scholars to use AI responsibly.

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